

Allogenes

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Antoinette Clark Wire

Translated by John D. Turner and Orval S. Wintermute

The tractate *Allogenes* is a revelation discourse in which a certain Allogenes receives divine auditions and visions and records them for his "son" Messos. The fictive nature of this repeated address of Allogenes to Messos is indicated by the name Allogenes, which means "stranger," "one of another race," and often in this period designates Seth or a representative of the Sethian spiritual race. The reader is thus encouraged to identify with Messos and learn from Allogenes how to overcome the fear and ignorance Allogenes initially feels, how to meditate on each step of revealed knowledge, and ultimately how to ascend into full realization of one's spiritual self within the divine.

Although *Allogenes* presents itself as a single revelation discourse, it can be divided into two parts. Part One (45,1-57,23) highlights five revelations of the female diety Youel to Allogenes. Her revelations are complex mythological descriptions of the divine powers, particularly the aeon of Barbelo. Part Two (57,24-69,19) describes in more philosophical language the ascent of Allogenes as a progressive revelation by the heavenly luminaries. Its final stage, the "primary revelation of the Unknown One," reveals the transcendent God as invisible, unfathomable, incomprehensible, "the spiritual, invisible Triple Power" which is "the best of the best" and exists, paradoxically, as "the nonbeing Existence."

The differences between these two parts of *Allogenes* can be explained in terms of different sources being used or in terms of the one writer's purpose. Source theories try to determine where certain traditions come from and how they have already developed. The Barbelo mythology of Part One is found also in *The Apocryphon of John* (BG 8502,2; NHC II,1; III,1; IV,1) where it is associated with an account of how Sophia brought deficiency into the universe. Allogenes' Barbelo Gnosticism, like that of *Zostrianos* (VIII,1) and *The Three Steles of Seth* (VII,5), is not interested in how evil began but in positive revelation of divine reality. Part Two of *Allogenes* also parallels *The Apocryphon of John* to the extent of a full-page description of the transcendent God in terms of what God is not. But again it departs from this tradition in the same direction as do *Zostrianos* and *The Three Steles of Seth* by presenting this knowledge as an ascent ritual in a way parallel to Hermetic Gnosticism (Corp. Herm. 1,24-26 and NHC VI,6). Apparently the author has taken both Barbelo Gnosticism and philosophical monism from the same general tradition as *The Apocryphon of John* and put them in sequence with certain linking passages for a single purpose.

Assuming that the reader has already been released from evil, the writer in the persona of Allogenes leads on up the heavenly path, praising the divine, into the blessing of knowledge, the

vitality of life and finally the existence that is nonexistence. The ascent rituals of Hermetism refer occasionally to community life, and *The Three Steles of Seth* uses the first person plural to praise God at each ascent level. But here the instructions are spoken to a single person who is reading and could be meant as self-help in an individual's search for God.

This tractate has attracted wide interest because the Neoplatonist Porphyry said that Plotinus attacked certain Gnostics who “produced revelations by Zoroaster and Zostrianos and Nicotheos and Allogenes and Messos and other such people” (Vit. Plot. 16). If this quote does indeed refer to this book named *Allogenes*, and to documents close to it (*Zostrianos* VIII,1 bears a coded subtitle, “Words of Zoroaster”) as many are proposing, it suggests a somewhat different relation of the Gnostics to later Platonism than is commonly assumed. Not only did Gnostics clearly borrow many philosophical themes from Platonism, but Platonists and Neoplatonists were being forced to deal with Gnostic schools as rivals to their own. And though Plotinus in his own tractate against the Gnostics does his best to ridicule their dualism, cult, and jargon, it is clearly the monistic Gnostics of the *Allogenes* sort who challenge him most. It is they who attribute to revelation the truths he is convinced that they have derived from Plato; it is they who believe that through self-knowledge they become superior to the heavenly bodies (Enn. II. 9.5-11). The question that remains is whether the Gnostics may not have had a reverse influence on Neoplatonism, specifically whether these gnostic texts could be the source of a certain existence-life-thought triad which is not attested in Neoplatonism before Proclus in the fifth century (Theol. 101-03).

An Alexandrian origin of the original Greek text of *Allogenes* not long after 300 C.E. would allow time for its Greek circulation and its Coptic translation before it was placed in the Nag Hammadi library early in the next century.